

The Physics of Transmission: Why Not All Light Is Created Equal for Data

By Malcolm R. Smith

Principal Manager, Savvy Security LLC

When we talk about transmitting data—whether across a Wi-Fi link, down a undersea cable, or through deep space—we are fundamentally talking about modulating electromagnetic waves. But a common question in systems architecture is: **Does the specific spectrum or wavelength of light change the information density and transmission performance?**

The short answer is **yes**. The physics of wave propagation, quantum photonics, and material optics dictate that different wavelengths excel at drastically different tasks.

1. Frequency Dictates Bandwidth (The Shannon-Hartley Limit)

At the foundation of information theory is the **Shannon-Hartley Theorem**, which proves that the maximum theoretical data throughput of any channel is directly proportional to its available bandwidth (B).

$$C = B \log_2 \left(1 + \frac{S}{N} \right)$$

Because electromagnetic frequency (ν) increases as wavelength (λ) shortens ($c = \lambda \nu$), higher-frequency spectrum regions contain vast operational bandwidths compared to lower-frequency radio waves:

- **2.4 GHz Wi-Fi:** A 1% operational bandwidth slice gives you roughly **24 MHz** of usable spectrum.
- **1550 nm Near-Infrared Laser:** A 1% operational bandwidth slice gives you **1.93 THz** of usable spectrum.

Higher frequencies allow us to package exponentially more bits per second into a carrier signal—the core reason why optical laser communication offers 10^x to 100^x the data throughput of traditional RF for deep-space communications.

2. The Medium Dictates the Winner (Attenuation Windows)

Having ultra-high potential bandwidth means nothing if the signal cannot pass through the physical medium without degrading. The choice of wavelength is usually dictated by **attenuation** (scattering and absorption):

- **Fiber Optics (\$1550\text{ nm}\$):** Standard silica glass fiber exhibits a global attenuation minimum ($\sim 0.2\text{ dB/km}$) around \$1550\text{ nm}\$ (the C-Band). Shorter wavelengths suffer from Rayleigh scattering ($\propto 1/\lambda^4$), while longer wavelengths hit the physical absorption limits of silica lattice vibrations.
- **Subsea Communications (\$450\text{ nm} - 550\text{ nm}\$):** Water absorbs infrared and radio waves almost instantaneously. However, clear seawater exhibits a tight optical transmission window in the **blue-green spectrum**, making \$450\text{ nm} - 550\text{ nm}\$ visible lasers the standard for underwater wireless optical communication.

3. Quantum Limits: Energy per Photon (\$E = h\nu\$)

If higher frequencies yield higher bandwidth, why not move straight to Ultraviolet or X-rays for maximum data rates?

The limiting factor is energy quantization. According to Planck’s relation ($E = h\nu$), higher-frequency photons carry significantly higher individual energies.

As you move up into high-energy ultraviolet or X-ray frequencies, communication enters a **photon-starved regime**. Generating and detecting these high-energy photons requires immense power, and individual photons introduce high quantum shot noise and hardware degradation.

Technical Summary

Spectrum Band	Wavelength	Primary Medium Strength	Key Performance Trade-off
Radio / Microwave	$1\text{ m} - 1\text{ mm}$	Penetrates solid obstacles and atmosphere	Low absolute bandwidth capacity
Near-Infrared (NIR)	$750\text{ nm} - 1600\text{ nm}$	Ultra-low loss in silica fiber (\$1550\text{ nm}\$)	Attenuated by fog/atmospheric moisture
Blue-Green Visible	$450\text{ nm} - 550\text{ nm}$	Low absorption in ocean water	High atmospheric scattering in air

Ultraviolet / X-Ray	$\lambda < 400 \text{ nm}$	Massive theoretical bandwidth potential	Quantum shot noise, high photon energy, material degradation
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Conclusion

Building high-throughput, secure communication architecture requires balancing **bandwidth density**, **medium attenuation**, and **quantum energy limits**. Infrared lasers dominate long-haul fiber backbones, radio dominates wide-area coverage, and blue-green optical links rule subsea domains.

What spectrum or medium challenges are you navigating in your own network architectures? Drop a comment below or connect with Savvy Security LLC.